

MORGAN QUINN

WRITING CRAFT

CLASS NOTES

# Want vs. Need: Building the Arc

CHARACTER PSYCHOLOGY IN FICTION

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## Mara's Promotion

Her current motive and her possible growth need do different jobs.

### WANT

Win the promotion.

### OUTCOME

A new role, more pay, and more authority.

### CURRENT MOTIVE

Feel worthy by being indispensable.

### BELIEF

'I only matter when I'm useful.'

### GROWTH NEED

Value herself beyond usefulness.

### POSSIBLE BEHAVIOR

Accept help and share credit.

## Want vs. Growth Need

A goal gives direction. A growth need suggests an internal change.

### WANT

The outcome the character pursues. Mara wants the promotion.

They may achieve it, lose it, or revise it.

### GROWTH NEED

A change in belief or behavior that could help them live or act differently.

Mara can accept her worth beyond usefulness.

The climax tests how they pursue the want and what they will risk.

## Three Arc Patterns

Track belief and behavior from the opening to the final choice.

### POSITIVE CHANGE

A limiting belief loosens. The character makes a choice they previously resisted.

### FLAT / STEADFAST

A sustaining belief holds under pressure. Acting on it affects the world around them.

### CORRUPTION EXAMPLE

The character chooses a more destructive belief or strategy. The external goal may still succeed.

## Pressure Across the Story

One possible progression, adaptable to your story's structure.

### OPENING

Mara earns approval by doing everything herself. Eli offers help. She refuses.

### ESCALATION

The workload becomes unsustainable. Sharing credit challenges her usual strategy.

### CLIMAX

Her boss offers promotion for taking Eli's credit. Her choice tests what worth means to her.

## Mara's Possible Endings

Same pressure: advancement is offered at Eli's expense.

Positive change: what can she do now that she resisted before?

Flat arc: what if she already valued fairness at the opening?

Corruption: what destructive choice could she justify? Winning the job is a separate outcome.

## Your Character Toolkit

Goal and motive explain what matters. Experience and belief help explain behavior.

An arc follows what changes, holds firm, or worsens under pressure.

Month 2 preview: defenses, relationships, and characters who justify harm.